

*Mt Tom & Basin Mountain
Sierra Club Sierra Peak Section (SPS) Peaks
Bishop, CA / Horton Lakes
September 19th & 20th*

After last weekend's outing deep into the Sierra this weekend was a makeup of sorts for the trip I ran way back in June. The plan was to once again attempt Mt Tom and Mt Basin as a two day trip and hopefully avoid the bad weather and potential thunderstorms that had chased us off the peak last time.



In addition to Kim and I we had Bill & Chris Payne along with one of our WTC students named Paige and her friend Debbie. A full trip for once! That rarely happens for some reason...

We all met at a campground above Bishop late Friday night / Saturday morning with Kim and I being the last ones to roll in around 2:30 in the morning. I still mercilessly woke everyone up at 5 am and starting prodding our sleepy group towards the trailhead.



Horton Lakes trailhead is theoretically accessible without a high clearance vehicle. Of course anyone who tells you that is either lying or really doesn't like their car. Nevertheless we were able to coax two vehicles the majority of the way there and then park beside the road.



We ran in to our first major complication during the hike in as Paige's friend Debbie was struggling a bit up the trail. I slowed the group down and allowed her plenty of time to rest and she soldiered on despite the obvious effort it was taking.



As a result we didn't get to camp near as early as I had planned. This wasn't necessarily a bad thing since it gave everyone a chance to acclimate but I was still determined to make a run up Basin that afternoon and I had figured I needed to leave camp by 2 pm at the latest.



At 1:45 pm we were still shy of camp so I left the group with Bill and took off ahead with Chris. After dropping off my gear at camp and leaving instructions what to do if I wasn't back before dark (basically don't worry, I probably bivvy'd up above) or the following morning (go for help, lost hiker) I set off to bag Basin solo.



The route to Basin involves climbing up a boulder strewn canyon and climbing a few contours for a total of about 3,100 ft of gain.

Rather than climb the established longer route I made a calculated attempt to shave off some horizontal distance by climbing up trickling rocky stream drainage.



Ok, that doesn't look so bad...



As usual there was a spot or two where I came to the conclusion I probably should have stuck to the regular route. But hey, at that point I was committed due to the time constraints so I pushed on and made it over the top.



Now it got steep and instead of solid (if somewhat slick and wet) rock I had varying size boulders all sitting in loose dirt. This had the pleasant side effect of causing me to slide down the hill with every step. Glancing at my watch I pushed on as quickly as possible aiming for the visible highpoint.



After a rather annoying climb I made the highpoint and was rewarded by a brief rock scramble. Of course that wasn't the peak. As soon as I got near the top I could see another point beyond that was higher.

So I ran over to the second point. By this time it was 5 pm and I had hoped to be on the peak by now. Of course that wasn't the peak either.



Damnit.

One 50 ft notch later and another scramble including a somewhat precarious climb along the ridge amid heavy wind I made the true summit and found the register.



I took a moment to pose for a picture with Mt Tom, the goal for the following day, in the background and quickly descended off the peak. By now it was 5:40 pm and I had quite a ways to descend to make it back to camp.



I descended with all haste, purposefully avoiding the route I came up for the safer but somewhat longer route descending the contours.



I made it back to Horton Lake just as it was getting too dark to see. My group had been keeping watch and when they saw my headlamp yelled across the lake. With some difficulty I picked my way around the lake and finally collapsed by the fire.

While I had been gone my group had set up camp, kicked back, and helped themselves to several liters of wine we had brought along. Debbie had unfortunately been feeling sick to her stomach, a combination of altitude and the effort involved in coming up the trail, but after I had been back in camp for a bit she reappeared looking much better.



Morning brought yet another one of those pre-dawn wakeups that make me a less than popular leader and we set out to bag Mt Tom. Debbie decided to wait around in camp and enjoy the lake in light of her difficulties the previous day and I fully supported that. The remaining 5 of us set out.



Mt Tom was supposed to be the easier of the two climbs. The first few miles are actually along a somewhat overgrown trail that quickly gains altitude above the lake before passing through the area of the Hanging Valley and Tungstar Mine.



Kim and I had made Hanging Valley mine during our previous trip and this time we choose to skip it in order to save time. Instead we continued towards the backside of Tom where there are the remains of Tungstar and an old tramway that used to serve it.







Smiles, remember what those look like...

I then pointed out the route to reach the peak. Basically we had to climb a 2,000 ft loose scree slope.





This took a number of hours to climb with several reroutes to get around patches where a single step would cause the surrounding hillside to start to slide down with you.

At long last we reached some solid rock and could do some honest climbing.



From here the route wasn't bad though there was one point in particular which felt a little hairy to some of the participants. They all did amazingly well and before long we climbed up one last pile of rocks to find ourselves standing on the highest point.



The lake in the background was where we starting.

A somber time of silence ensued



We had managed to climb the peak on the perfect day as the skies were clear and we could see forever in every direction.

Sadly we had now reached the part that follows after every euphoric peak ascent which is the inevitable descent.



My group was growing noticeably tired but did a great job of keeping separated and calling out rock fall as we descending 2,000 ft back to the mine. We were all overjoyed to reach the trail again.



The descent to camp felt much longer than it had when we climbed in that morning and by now everyone was feeling tired. Add to that the fact that once we made camp we still had to pack up and hike out 5 miles or so to the car before driving home. Ick.

We made camp around sundown to find Debbie looking much to clean and rested having enjoyed some additional sleep and a brief swim in the lake. She did an excellent job of getting hot drink into everyone and we slowly pulled our camp down and got ready to leave.



By now it was dark and so we ended up pulling a Matt special and hiking out via headlamps. Everyone was feeling much better but it was still after 11 pm Sunday night when we made it back to the cars and midnight by the time we were back on the road to Bishop.

At this point I finally looked at the clock and realized a few things.

1. It was midnight
2. Bishop is 5+ hours from home
3. I have a 6:45 am flight out of Orange County that requires I get to the airport a little after 5 am.

Ouch.

Fortunately Kim was with me and she put in a heroic effort driving most of the way home. Sadly it appears every single fast food restaurant between Bishop and Mohave was closed so the post trip meal, the thing you look forward to for the entire trip, was a cherry Hostess pie and a bag of pretzels. Yum.

We made it back to my apartment at 5 am after a much liberal interpretation of the speed limit along the way. I ran in to shower and change while Kim collapsed on the floor. She drove me to the airport and I made my flight with 20 minutes to spare.

Monday was a bit of a long tired day to say the least. Happily the rest of the group was all able to stay in Bishop and take a much more leisurely pace home the following day.